

ENTERTAINMENT

ROCKET TO **FAME**

Season 2 of *Rocket Boys* is just the launch pad Jim Sarbh needed to showcase his seasoned acting skills

There is something about Jim Sarbh's tenacity as a performer that resists easy categorisation. Describing him as a character actor feels inadequate and slotting him as a supporting actor seems almost cruel, considering the heft his electric presence is capable of bringing to any narrative. Since debuting in Ram Madhvani's *Neerja* (2016), Sarbh has forged one of the most exciting trajectories in Hindi cinema, delicately straddling mainstream blockbuster ensembles like *Padmaavat* (2017), *Sanju* (2018) and *Gangubai Kathiawadi* (2022) and experimental choices like *A Death in the Gunj* (2016) and *Photograph* (2019). "I never think about one particular genre or one particular type of story [when choosing scripts]. I've done period pieces, biopics and dramas. I've played the bad guy and I've played the good guy," says Sarbh, looking back at his diverse filmography. A common thread in all his work—across plays, movies, web series—the actor says, is his insistence on being a part of compelling stories.

Still, even though Sarbh wielded his own predictability as a weapon, it also made it somewhat difficult to envision him as a leading actor. That changed almost overnight last year with Abhay Pannu's ***Rocket Boys,*** the widely acclaimed **SonyLIV** series that tracked the lives of Dr Homi Bhabha and Dr Vikram Sarabhai, the two scientists who spearheaded India's nuclear energy and space programmes. Sarbh's magnetic turn as Dr Homi Bhabha shouldered the series, enlivening its efficiency and giving a face to the Parsi everyman.

In many ways, it felt like a role that was tailor-made for the actor. By his own admission, shooting most of the show's widely anticipated second season before the first came out and attained its own popularity helped take the pressure off, letting him focus only on being truthful to the script. "For the remaining bits that needed to be shot, Abhay [Pannu] really made sure that we built on the strengths from the first season and addressed some of the weaknesses."

Being a part of *Rocket Boys* over two seasons helped Sarbh re-evaluate his own approach to acting. For one, he became more aware of the challenges that accompanied improvising scenes on a long-format project. "If you improvise with lines a bit too much, you can throw off your co-actors and [wrapping] the whole thing will take more time. But when you're shooting so much in a day, you don't always have time," says Sarbh. On both *Made in Heaven* (2019—) and *Rocket Boys*, the 35-year-old actor found himself improvising more and more with his own approach, experimenting instead with the physicality of his characters. It's something he hopes audiences will notice in his turn as a shrewd lawyer in Ashima Chibber's *Mrs. Chatterjee Vs Norway*, the actor's other big release of the month.

In his exciting journey, Jim Sarbh has delicately straddled both mainstream cinema and experimental choices

Yet, for someone who has visibly evolved as an actor, Sarbh claims that his sensibilities have remained unaffected in the past six years. "I guess the real difference is that now I have more opportunities and can be pickier," he says. The ability to say no is a privilege for any actor, but Sarbh's filmography is also telling of the kind of projects he chooses to take up. His collaborations with veteran filmmakers such as Sanjay Leela Bhansali and Rajkumar Hirani are offset by his constant penchant for working with new directors, whether it is Ashima Chibber or Abhay Pannu. "[As an actor], it's less of a gamble if you're working with established voices. But I guess I'm a gambler." ■

Poulomi Das